

An aerial photograph of a coastal city, likely Brisbane, Australia. The image shows a harbor with several boats and a large industrial area with various buildings and structures. In the background, there are mountains under a clear blue sky. The foreground shows a parking lot with several cars.

STATE RELOCATION GUIDE • AUSTRALIA

Queensland

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Queensland.

Ethicare Resourcing

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ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Queensland

Queensland Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

Queensland is the state Australians themselves move to: winter sun, beaches that work all year, and housing that still lets an ordinary salary buy an ordinary house. For clinicians it adds the country's fastest-growing health demand — and a decentralised system that means real careers far beyond the capital.

The state people move to on purpose

Brisbane holds around two and a half million people and has grown out of its big-country-town reputation into a genuine river city — a rebuilt centre, a strong hospital cluster, and the 2032 Olympics on the calendar. An hour south, the Gold Coast is Australia's sixth-largest city and its most famous beach strip; an hour north, the Sunshine Coast pairs surf towns with one of the newest hospital precincts in the country.

Then the state keeps going — for two thousand kilometres. Townsville and Cairns anchor the tropical north; Toowoomba sits atop the range inland; Rockhampton, Mackay and Bundaberg serve the long central coast. Queensland is the most decentralised state in Australia: one person in two lives outside the capital's orbit, and the health system is built to match.

The honest costs are heat and distance. Summer is hot and humid everywhere and properly tropical in the north, with a real cyclone season; and the state's size means the far-flung postings are genuinely far. But the value case is the strongest of the big three states: south-east Queensland delivers coast-city life at prices Sydney and Melbourne stopped offering a decade ago.

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

Queensland is where we send the most families, and the state where "which part?" matters most — Brisbane and Cairns are as different as London and Lisbon. Where we think it's the wrong answer, we say so.

The state, in nine numbers

~5.6M

People, in Australia's most decentralised state — nearly half live outside greater Brisbane.

~2.5M

In Greater Brisbane — the river city, rebuilt and growing toward its 2032 Olympics.

120+

Public hospitals across sixteen hospital and health services — the most geographically spread system in the country.

~7,000 km

Of coastline, from the NSW border to the Cape — with the Great Barrier Reef offshore for 2,300 of them.

~650,000

On the Gold Coast — Australia's sixth-largest city, an hour south of Brisbane by road or rail.

~400,000

On the Sunshine Coast, with one of Australia's newest hospital precincts.

300+

Days of sunshine a year in the south-east. Winter is the season people move here for.

UTC+10

No daylight saving — Queensland opts out. Summer evenings run earlier than the southern states'.

2032

The Brisbane Olympics — a decade of hospital, transport and housing investment already under way.

Six things you only learn once you're here

Winter is the payoff

Twenty-two degrees, dry and blue, June through August — while Melbourne shivers. It resets what you think a year feels like, and it is why the southerners keep arriving.

Summer is the price

Hot, humid and stormy in the south-east; monsoonal in the north. Air conditioning is infrastructure, the afternoon storm is theatre, and January errands happen before ten.

No daylight saving is a real thing

Summer light from 4.45am, dark by seven. Early starts come naturally; long summer evenings don't. Queenslanders vote to keep it this way and enjoy the argument.

"Queensland" is several places

The south-east corner is one life; the tropical north another; the outback west a third. The state is a direction, not a destination — choose your hundred kilometres.

The regions carry real hospitals

Townsville and Cairns run tertiary-level services a full day's drive from Brisbane. Regional Queensland is not a compromise posting; it is where much of the state's medicine happens.

Cyclone season is managed, not mythical

North of about Bundaberg, November to April brings watches and the occasional real one. Building codes, warning systems and local habits are built around it – take the induction seriously.

A note on Country

Queensland spans hundreds of Aboriginal nations – Yuggera and Turrbal around Brisbane, Kombumerri on the Gold Coast, Yidinji and Djabugay in the far north – and the Torres Strait Islands, whose peoples are a distinct First Nations culture. Torres Strait Islander health is a significant part of the state's system, particularly in the north.

Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings, and health services work in partnership with community-controlled organisations. Take the cultural induction seriously; in the north it is central to the job.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Queensland specifically. Anything true of Australia generally – Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools – lives once in **Moving to Australia** rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read **Why Queensland** for the full case – and what we'd ask you to weigh, and **Where clinicians live**, because the south-east corner and the tropical north are decisions of a completely different kind.

Why Queensland

Queensland Guide · Chapter 2 of 9

Queensland's case is the one Australians vote for with removal trucks: the same national salary buys more house, more sunshine and more weekend here than in either of the bigger states. The honest counterweights are summer, storms and sheer distance.

The arithmetic

Public-sector clinical pay is set by state awards, and we don't quote figures until we've verified them against the current instruments. The structure is what matters: Queensland pay is broadly comparable with the southern states, while south-east Queensland housing runs clearly below Sydney and visibly below Melbourne. That gap is the state's whole pitch, and it survives the recent boom — narrower than it was, still real.

Go regional and the multiplier stacks: Townsville, Cairns, Mackay, Rockhampton and Bundaberg price family homes at a fraction of the south-east, and the further and more remote the posting, the stronger the incentives attached. Queensland is where the regional package system works hardest, because the state needs it most.

What you trade: summers that ask something of you, a cyclone season in the north, and distances that make "popping down to Sydney" a flight, always.

A typical week

Monday to Friday

Brisbane: 25–45 minutes, train or busway if you're wise. Gold or Sunshine Coast: 15–25.

Regional cities: ten, with parking.

Before work

The 5am beach swim or river run — the no-daylight-saving dawn makes early exercise a mass habit, not a virtue.

After work

Winter: barbecue weather all through July. Summer: the pool, the aircon, and the 4pm storm rolling in like scheduled entertainment.

Saturday

Nippers or netball in the morning, markets after, the beach or the river the rest. The outdoor family weekend is the state's default setting.

Sunday

Hinterland waterfalls, a national park, the bay islands — or in the north, the reef, which stops feeling like a bucket-list item and becomes a day out.

School holidays

You live where the rest of the country goes on holiday. Visitors will find you; budget for the spare room being popular.

The six things people ask us

Is there enough work?

Can I actually buy a house?

How bad is summer, really?

Brisbane, Gold Coast or Sunshine Coast?

What about the tropical north?

Is it good with children?

When we'd point you south

You'd wilt in the humidity

If a sticky February sounds unbearable, believe yourself. Victoria and the southern coasts exist.

You want the deepest subspecialty pool

Brisbane's is strong and growing; Sydney's and Melbourne's are deeper. Quaternary careers may still point south.

Big-city culture is the point

Brisbane's scene is good now and still a size down. If nightly theatre and headline acts matter most, the southern capitals win.

Cyclone season would keep you up

North of Bundaberg it is a real annual rhythm. If that maths doesn't sit, stay south-east — or south.

Family is elsewhere

The eternal rule: proximity to your people beats sunshine. Perth is five hours; Auckland is four.

Where we'd steer you instead

Want the biggest market and the harbour? **New South Wales**.

Want the culture city at a discount? **Victoria**.

Weighing the Tasman? The master's **Australia vs New Zealand** chapter is the place to start.

In our experience

Queensland suits clinicians who want the salary to buy a life, not just a postcode — and who'd rather spend winter outdoors. Our one firm piece of advice: visit in February before you commit, not July.

Queensland at a glance

Queensland Guide · Chapter 3 of 9

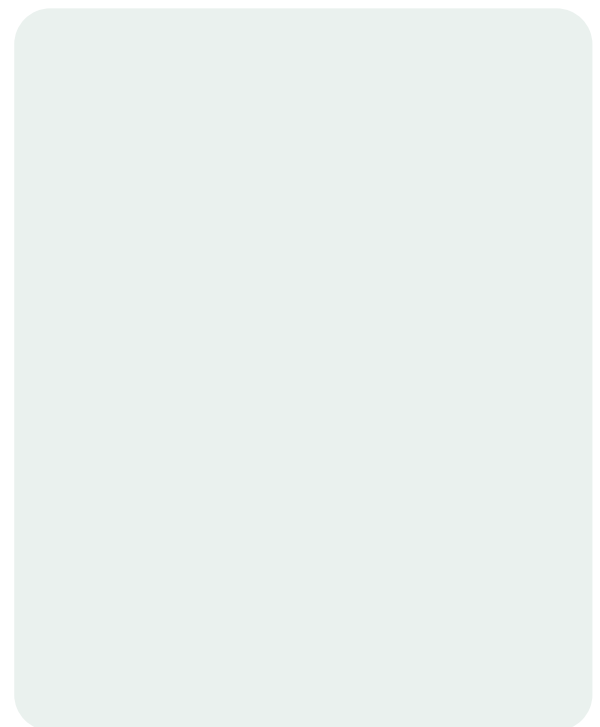
Queensland runs from subtropical river city to monsoonal tropics to red-dirt outback – a state so long that its two ends have different seasons. Understanding the three Queenslands is the fastest way to understand which one is yours.

The three Queenslands

The south-east corner is where two-thirds of the state lives: Brisbane on its river, the Gold Coast's forty-kilometre beach strip south to the border, the Sunshine Coast's surf towns north, and the Scenic Rim's green hinterland behind. Subtropical – hot wet summers, warm dry winters, storm season as the soundtrack.

The coast runs north for two thousand kilometres: Bundaberg and the southern reef gateways, Rockhampton and Mackay serving cattle and coal country, then the true tropics – Townsville, dry and garrison-tough; Cairns, wet and rainforest-green, where the reef meets the Daintree. Monsoon wet seasons, glorious dry winters, cyclone watch from November.

The inland climbs the range to Toowoomba's gardens, then runs west through farm and cattle country into the outback proper – Longreach, Mount Isa's mining city, and distances where medicine is flown, not driven.



Where Brisbane sits, with the straight-line distance to Cairns and Townsville

The seasons, south-east corner

Summer
Dec – Feb
29–32°C

Hot, humid, stormy

Autumn

Mar – May

24–28°C

The humidity breaks

Winter

Jun – Aug

21–23°C

Dry, blue, the payoff

Spring

Sep – Nov

25–29°C

Warming, jacarandas

Indicative Brisbane daytime highs. Cairns and Townsville run hotter with a true wet season (roughly December–April); the inland west adds real heat in summer and cold clear nights in winter.

What the numbers don't tell you

Winter is the season the state is famous for. Dry, cloudless, twenty-two degrees — from June to August the south-east has arguably the best city weather on earth, and the north has its "dry", which is the tourist season for a reason.

The storm season is genuine theatre. South-east summer afternoons build purple thunderheads that break at four with hail warnings and drenching rain, then clear by dinner. Download the radar app early; locals treat it as a spectator sport with rules.

The wet season is a different contract. North of about Mackay, December to April means monsoonal rain, road cuts, and the cyclone watch. It is well-managed and locals plan around it — but it is real, and the induction your service gives you is not a formality.

No daylight saving changes the shape of days. Summer light starts before five and ends by seven. The state runs early: 6am gyms full, 7am meetings normal, evening barbecues in winter rather than summer.

Sun protection is clinical-grade serious here. Queensland has the world's highest melanoma rates. Hats, rash shirts and 50+ are school policy and should be yours — the master's [Living in Australia](#) covers the everyday rules.

Where things are, in travel time

Brisbane → Gold Coast

About an hour by road or train to the southern end's health precinct.

Brisbane → Sunshine Coast

A little over an hour north to the new hospital spine.

Brisbane → Toowoomba

90 minutes up the range.

Brisbane → Bundaberg / Rockhampton

4.5 / 7 hours by road – or short flights, which is how the state actually works.

Brisbane → Townsville / Cairns

2-hour flights. Driving is 13–16 hours and a road trip, not a commute.

Brisbane → Sydney / Melbourne

1.5 / 2-hour flights, constantly.

Words you'll hear

SEQ South-east Queensland – Brisbane plus the two coasts. The corner.

The wet / the dry The north's two seasons. The calendar up there.

FNQ Far North Queensland – Cairns and beyond.

Straddie / Moreton The bay islands – Brisbane's weekend sand.

The hinterland The green ranges behind either coast – waterfalls and lookouts.

Stinger season Box-jellyfish months in the north – swim between the nets.

Go Card SEQ's transport card – trains, busways, ferries, trams.

The Isa Mount Isa – the outback mining city, and shorthand for "properly remote".

The short version

Three Queensland: the subtropical corner, the tropical coast, the outback west. Winter is the universal payoff; summer asks more the further north you go. Which Queensland you choose decides everything else – **Where clinicians live** is next.

Healthcare in Queensland

Queensland Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Queensland runs the most geographically spread public health system in Australia: sixteen hospital and health services covering everything from a capital-city tertiary cluster to islands in the Torres Strait. For a clinician, that spread is the story – the state's depth is not all in one place.

The shape of the system

Public care is organised into **sixteen hospital and health services (HHSs)** – each with its own board, geography and recruitment. The south-east corner holds several metropolitan services covering Brisbane's hospital cluster, the Gold Coast's precinct and the Sunshine Coast's new spine. Then the map opens out: services centred on Toowoomba, Bundaberg, Rockhampton, Mackay, Townsville, Cairns – and beyond them the truly remote services covering the west and the Torres Strait and Cape.

Registration is national through Ahpra; **hiring is service by service**. The practical consequence: "moving to Queensland" is really choosing an HHS, and the same profession can mean a tertiary team in Brisbane, a regional department in Mackay, or a fly-in clinic run out of Cairns.

What makes Queensland unusual is that tertiary-level medicine exists *outside* the capital: Townsville anchors genuine tertiary services for the north, and Cairns runs major-hospital medicine at the rainforest's edge. The state built it that way because Brisbane is simply too far from its own north. How Medicare and the public-private split work is national, and lives once in the master's [How the health system works](#).

What the work is like

Growth is the constant

The south-east is adding people – and hospital capacity – faster than anywhere in Australia, with the 2032 build-up compounding it. New units, new roles, constant recruitment.

The north is a career, not a posting

Townsville and Cairns offer tertiary and major-hospital medicine with tropical, Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander health at the centre – work that exists nowhere else in the country at this scale.

Rural and remote, properly

The western services and the Torres Strait run medicine by air and telehealth across enormous distances – broad scope, strong incentives, real isolation. The master's [Regional life](#) is the honest account.

Retrieval is a system, not an exception

Aeromedical transfer knits the state together. Wherever you work, stabilise-and-fly is part of the clinical culture, and the further out, the more of it you own.

Seasonal rhythms are clinical rhythms

Storm season in the south-east, the wet and stinger season in the north, tourist surges on both coasts – the caseload has a calendar here.

Pay is set by state awards

Each profession has its own instruments, with allowances, packaging and – distinctively here – remote-area incentives layered on top. We quote figures only after verifying them against the current award; see [Pay & conditions](#).

Queensland's depth is not all in one place, and this is why: the state is long enough that Brisbane is too far from its own north to serve it. So the north got its own tertiary medicine.

Up the coast

Each of these is a separate hospital and health service with its own board and its own recruitment – and the two at the far end run tertiary and major-hospital medicine in their own right.

Brisbane Sunshine Coast Rockhampton Mackay Townsville Cairns

And away from it

Inland and island services where medicine runs by air and telehealth – broad scope, strong incentives, real isolation.

Toowoomba & the Darling Downs The western services Torres Strait & Cape

"Moving to Queensland" is really choosing one of these – and the same profession means a tertiary team in the south-east, a regional department in the middle, or a fly-in clinic run out of the far north.

Working with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities

Queensland is the only state whose health system serves two distinct First Nations peoples – Aboriginal nations across the mainland, and Torres Strait Islander communities in the islands and the northern coast. Community-controlled health organisations are major partners, and in the northern and western services, First Nations health is much of the daily work rather than a programme beside it.

You are not expected to arrive expert. You are expected to take the cultural induction seriously – in the far north it is core clinical preparation – and to learn whose Country and whose islands your service stands on.

What to ask at interview

Which HHS and which facility – and does the role involve outreach, fly-in clinics or telehealth to outlying communities?

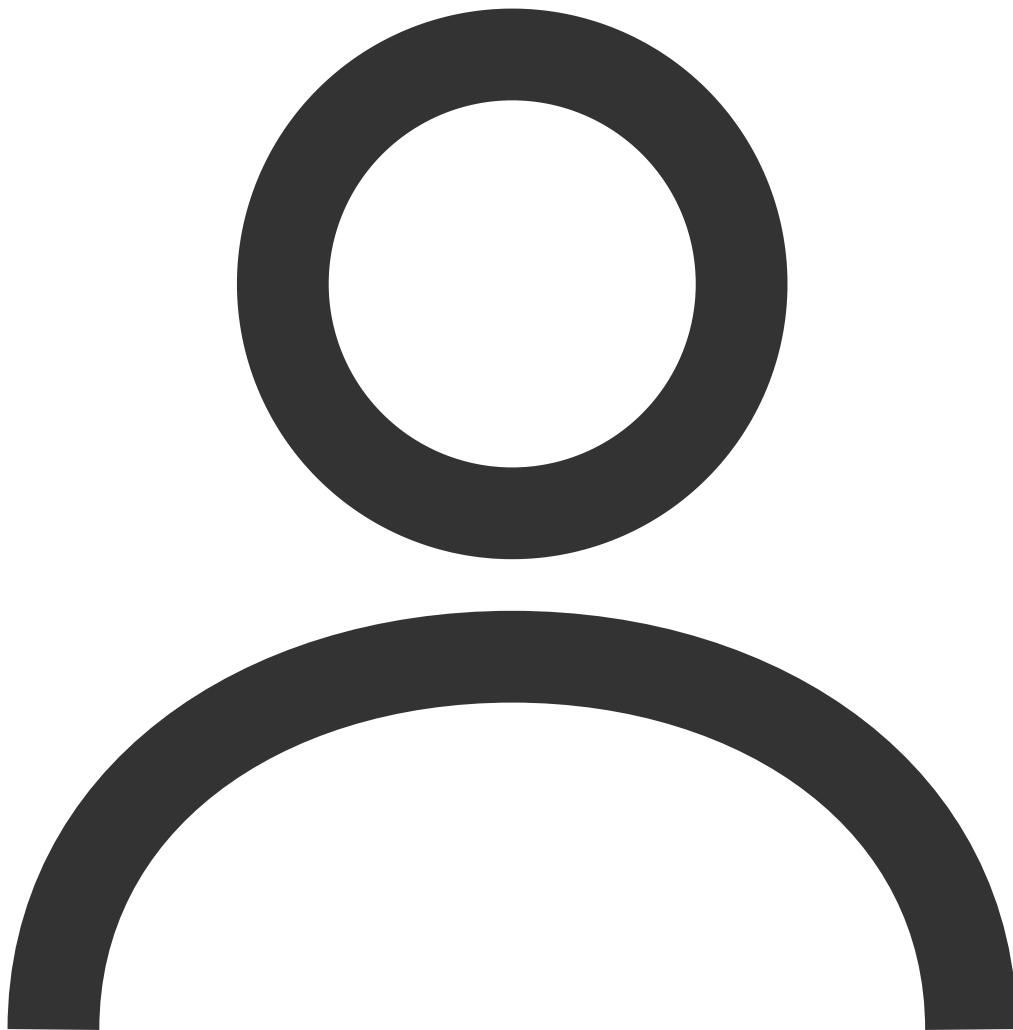
What is the roster pattern, and how are on-call, penalties and allowances handled under the relevant award?

For regional and remote roles: exactly what incentives, accommodation and leave provisions apply – and for how long?

What is the wet-season / cyclone operational plan, and what does it mean for my roster? (North of Bundaberg, ask this seriously.)

What supervision, orientation and CPD support exists for clinicians new to Australia – and how does CPD work this far from the southern cities?

Where does complex work refer to, and how much of the retrieval pathway do I own?



Sophie

Sophie's insight

Queensland is where I place the most families, and the pattern is always the same: they come for the winter and stay for the mortgage. My honest advice is to take the north seriously – Townsville and Cairns offer careers the southern capitals can't, and the clinicians who try them almost never come back early.

Sophie Careem Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

Before you can start

Ahpra registration, English-language evidence and the visa that goes with your role are national processes, identical in every state. They are explained once, properly, in the master's [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

Ethicare



What we're recruiting for now, by profession and by state.
Master guide



How awards, allowances and remote incentives work – and what to verify before you sign.

Where clinicians live

Queensland Guide · Chapter 5 of 9

Queensland's first decision is which Queensland: the south-east corner, the tropical north, or the regional coast between. Within the corner, the second decision — Brisbane, Gold Coast or Sunshine Coast — is happily low-stakes, because they're an hour apart.

FIRST PICK YOUR QUEENSLAND

The state runs on three housing markets, not one. The good news sits in the note underneath.

The south-east corner

Brisbane, the Gold Coast and the Sunshine Coast — most of the jobs, most of the choice, and city prices that still sit visibly under Sydney and Melbourne equivalents.

The tropical north

Townsville and Cairns run their own tertiary-grade systems with housing a fraction of the corner's — the trade is distance and a wet season, not career ceiling.

The coast between

Mackay, Rockhampton, Bundaberg and their neighbours: hospital towns where a family home costs least of all, and recruitment rarely closes.

Within the corner, a wrong guess barely costs you — Brisbane and both coasts sit roughly an hour from each other, so a wrong guess is a move, not a migration.

Brisbane

The inner ring

New Farm, Paddington, West End – Queenslander houses on stilts, river walks, and the café-and-market life. The premium end, and still visibly below equivalent Sydney or Melbourne.

The middle north and south

Ashgrove to Chermside, Camp Hill to Mount Gravatt – the family value ring, on busways and train lines, where most relocating households land.

The riverside east

Bulimba, Hawthorne, Manly's bayside – ferries to work, sailing clubs, weekend markets. Family-scaled with water attached.

The growth corridors

North Lakes, Springfield, Ripley – new estates, new schools and the most house for the money in the metro area; commute and summer heat are the trade.

Ipswich

The historic city inside the corridor – its own hospital, heritage streets and prices that startle southerners. Rising fast.

The two coasts

Gold Coast – the beach city

Australia's sixth-largest city behind forty kilometres of surf: high-rise energy at Surfers, family suburbs at Burleigh and Palm Beach, hinterland villages behind. A major health precinct of its own, and the light rail stitching it together.

Gold Coast – the canals

The waterfront-home suburbs – boats at the back fence at prices that still undercut Sydney's harbour dreams by multiples.

Sunshine Coast

Caloundra to Noosa – the family-scaled coast: surf towns, the new hospital spine at Birtinya, and a hinterland of market villages. Calmer than the Gold Coast, priced increasingly confidently.

Noosa & the premium pockets

The exception to Queensland value – Noosa, Burleigh's beachfront and the best canal addresses run on southern money. Lovely; budget accordingly.

The regional cities

Toowoomba

The garden city atop the range, ninety minutes inland – a genuine regional hub with its own hospital, cool nights, and the state's most settled four-season feel.

Bundaberg & the southern reef coast

Sugar-town scale with Bargara's beaches attached, turtles nesting up the road, and family homes at prices that end conversations.

Rockhampton & Mackay

The central coast's working cities — beef and mining country with solid hospitals, islands offshore, and strong incentive packages.

Townsville

The north's capital in the dry belt — tertiary-level medicine, a garrison-city spine, Magnetic Island twenty minutes offshore. The serious northern career move.

Cairns

The tropical one — major-hospital medicine between reef and rainforest, an international workforce, and the wet season as the annual contract.

The far west & the Torres Strait

Mount Isa's mining medicine and the island clinics of the Strait — the remotest postings in this collection, with the incentives and the isolation to match.

Three things to check before you sign

Air conditioning and orientation, not just the address. A Queensland summer in a west-facing rental without decent aircon is a lesson learned once. Ask what's installed and what the power bills run.

Flood mapping, at the exact address. River and creek flooding is part of the state's history — check the council flood map and ask about the property's record before signing; insurance prices it even when agents don't mention it.

The school catchment — and the visa fee question. Catchments bind here as everywhere; and on a temporary visa, read the master's [School fees on a visa](#) before you budget.

Most clinicians we move rent for six to twelve months first — long enough to learn whether they're corner people, coast people or north people. In Queensland those are different lives, and the state is generous enough to let you test them.

Getting around

Queensland Guide · Chapter 6 of 9

Queensland transport is two systems: a connected south-east corner of trains, busways, ferries and light rail — currently the cheapest urban transport in the country — and a state beyond it that runs on aircraft and long, straight highways.

The south-east corner

Brisbane's **rail network** radiates through the suburbs and runs the spine of the corner — one line south to the Gold Coast, one north toward the Sunshine Coast — while the **busways** (grade-separated bus motorways, a Brisbane speciality) cover the corridors trains miss. The **CityCat ferries** make the river a commute: if your hospital sits near a terminal, the boat is the best journey to work in Australia.

The Gold Coast adds its **light rail** down the beach spine; everything runs on one **Go Card** (or contactless), and Queensland's flat-fare experiment has made public transport almost free — check the current fare policy, but budget approximately nothing.

Driving, honestly

One toll network, mild by Sydney standards

Brisbane's tunnels and the airport link are tolled; the coasts largely aren't. A tag sorts it; the monthly bill is a fraction of NSW's.

The M1 is the pressure point

Brisbane–Gold Coast at peak is the corner's one genuinely bad drive. The train exists; use it.

Storm-season driving is a skill

Flash flooding closes underpasses fast. "If it's flooded, forget it" is the state's road-safety mantra, and it is not decorative.

Parking is easy outside the centre

Hospital and suburban parking is far more forgiving than the southern capitals. Ask at interview anyway.

The rest of the state: fly

Brisbane Airport

The third gateway – direct to Asia, the Pacific and the Gulf, and the domestic hub the state's health system quietly runs on.

The regional network

Townsville, Cairns, Mackay, Rockhampton and Bundaberg all fly to Brisbane multiple times daily. Regional clinicians treat the 6am flight as a bus.

Cairns international

The north's own gateway – direct to Asia in season, which changes the trip home for FNQ clinicians.

The highways

The Bruce runs the coast for 1,700 kilometres – a road trip with a cult following and roadhouse rituals. Inland, distances are honest and fuel stops are planned, not assumed.

Distances worth knowing

Journey	Typical time
Brisbane CBD → hospital cluster (Herston / South Brisbane)	10–15 min by busway or ferry
Brisbane → Gold Coast	~1 hr by train or road
Brisbane → Sunshine Coast	~1 hr 15 by road
Brisbane → Toowoomba	~1 hr 30 by road
Brisbane → Bundaberg	~4 hr 30 by road, or a 1-hr flight
Brisbane → Rockhampton / Mackay	7 / 10 hr by road – fly
Brisbane → Townsville / Cairns	2-hr flights; 13–16 hr drives
Cairns → the Torres Strait	2-hr flight to Horn Island, then boats
Brisbane → Sydney / Melbourne	1.5 / 2-hr flights, constantly

Off-peak estimates. Add for the M1 at commuter hours, and treat wet-season road closures in the north as a when, not an if.

Licence conversion, buying and registering a car, and the practicalities of Australian driving are national topics, covered once in the master's [Living in Australia](#).

Cost of living

Queensland Guide · Chapter 7 of 9

Queensland's value case survived the boom, but it needs saying honestly: the corner is no longer cheap — it is cheaper. The regional cities still are cheap, and the gap between the two is the most useful thing in this chapter.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the relationship between places — which suburb, ring or region you choose — and the judgement about which costs catch people out. That is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare it against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

The shape of the money

Clinical pay is set by state awards and is broadly comparable with the southern states; we don't print figures until we've verified them against the current instruments. The outgoings side is where Queensland argues: south-east housing runs clearly below Sydney and below Melbourne, and the regional cities run at half the corner or better — with incentives often stacked on top.

The interstate migration that made the state famous also moved its prices: Brisbane's boom years closed some of the old gap, and the premium pockets — Noosa, beachfront Burleigh, the best canals — now price on southern money. The middle of the market held: **ordinary suburbs, both coasts included, remain buyable on clinical incomes**, which is the sentence that matters.

The sunshine hides two costs worth naming early: summer electricity, because air conditioning is infrastructure here; and insurance, which prices flood and cyclone honestly even when nobody mentions them at the open home — markedly so in the north.

Renting, by region

Inner Brisbane

The state's top of range for apartments and Queenslanders alike – a clear step below equivalent Sydney, roughly level-pegging with middle Melbourne.

Middle-ring Brisbane & Ipswich corridor

The family value belt – where the buy-within-two-years plan still computes.

Gold Coast

Beach suburbs price confidently, the canal premium is real, and the towers offer the corner's most accessible rents. Wide spread; choose deliberately.

Sunshine Coast

Risen hardest of the three – the family-coast reputation now carries a price. Still below the southern capitals for the same postcode-to-beach maths.

Toowoomba & the regional cities

Bundaberg, Rockhampton, Mackay – family homes at prices that end the housing conversation, frequently paired with incentives.

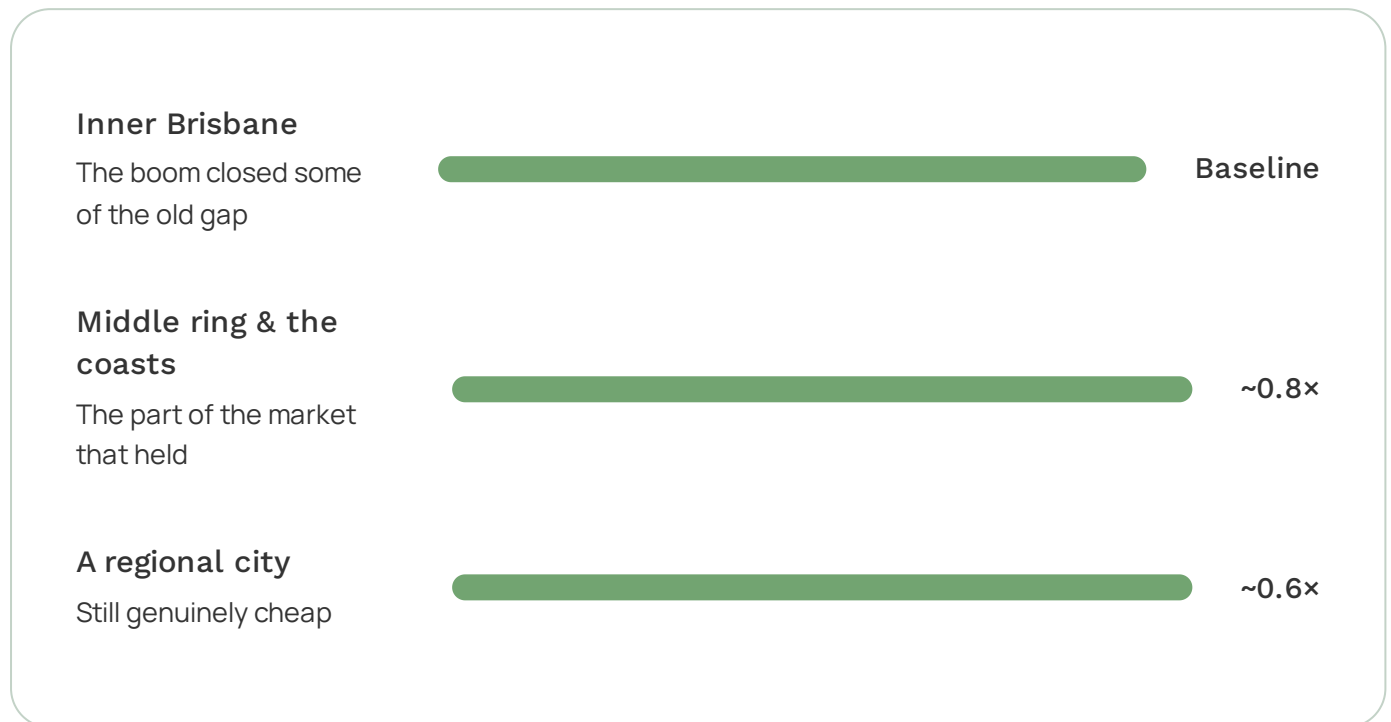
Townsville & Cairns

The north's cities remain genuinely affordable; insurance is the line that bites back. Net-net still firmly ahead.

NO LONGER CHEAP. STILL CHEAPER.

Monthly rent for the same room or small one-bedroom, at true relative scale.

The gap between the corner and the regional cities is the most useful number in this chapter.



Cheaper than Sydney and Melbourne, not cheap — that distinction is the whole chapter.

One line runs in your favour whichever tier you choose: south-east Queensland's flat fare is currently the cheapest urban transport in the country.

Indicative prices that change over time. The transport line is not a typo — SEQ's flat-fare policy is currently the cheapest urban transport in the country; check the current scheme.

The costs the sunshine hides

Summer power

Air conditioning through a humid January is a real bill. Solar is everywhere for a reason — ask whether the rental has it and who gets the benefit.

Insurance, north of Bundaberg

Cyclone and flood risk price into premiums sharply in the north. Get quotes before committing to buy; renters feel it more gently.

School fees on a temporary visa

Queensland generally charges nothing: 482 dependants are waived, with a small annual application fee. The rule and the other states sit in the master's [School fees on a visa](#).

Health cover for your visa

Many visas require private cover, separate from Medicare – national detail, covered in Immigration & visas.

Work out your own numbers

Compare cities

Numbeo · cost of living



Brisbane, Gold Coast and Cairns prices against your current city.

(<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Brisbane>)

Plan your budget



The Australian government's free budgeting tool.

(<https://moneysmart.gov.au/budgeting/budget-planner>)

Property



Live rents and sales — compare the corner and the regions early.

(<https://www.realestate.com.au/rent/in-qld>)

Master guide



Flights, shipping, bonds and the first ninety days – budgeted once, properly.
Sanity check



A cleaner side-by-side of two cities. Worth running when Numbeo looks off.

(<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>)

Official data



Slower than the comparison sites, and the one to trust on the direction of travel.

(<https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation>)

The honest summary

The corner is cheaper than Sydney and Melbourne, not cheap – and still the best big-city buying maths in the country. The regional cities halve the housing line and add incentives. The hidden lines are summer power and northern insurance; budget both and the sunshine is honestly priced.

Food, shopping & the everyday

Queensland Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

Queensland's everyday life is built around its weather the way Melbourne's is built around its coffee: outdoors, early, and unbothered. The food scene has grown into the climate — markets, seafood and verandah dining — and the state's real speciality is the shape of an ordinary day.

The early-start operating system

No daylight saving plus subtropical light means the state runs early: beaches busy at five, gyms full at six, 7am meetings unremarkable, school drop-off in sunglasses. Evenings are short in summer and glorious in winter — the barbecue season inverts here, peaking in July when the south shivers. Newcomers fight the rhythm for a month and then convert; fighting it longer is the one reliable way to dislike Queensland.

Eating out

Brisbane has grown up

The river city's dining precincts — Howard Smith Wharves, South Bank, the James Street end — now hold their own against the southern capitals, at a friendlier bill.

The coasts do casual brilliantly

Burleigh's headland dinners, Noosa's river restaurants, surf-club bistros the whole coast long — the surf club is the state's honest institution: cheap, licensed, and pointed at the ocean.

Seafood is the local produce

Moreton Bay bugs, mud crab, tiger prawns, reef fish north of Rocky — the fish-and-chips baseline here embarrasses most countries' fine dining.

No tipping, honest menus

The price is the price and waitstaff earn a wage. Same national rule, same pleasant surprise at the till.

Markets and what the state grows

Queensland grows the country's tropical larder: mangoes and avocados that make the southern supermarkets look apologetic, bananas from the north, strawberries through winter, sugar the whole coast long. The **weekend farmers' markets** — Jan Powers in Brisbane, the coast markets at Burleigh and Noosa, Rusty's in Cairns — are produce-first and genuinely cheap in season.

The **Granite Belt** behind Toowoomba is the state's quiet wine country — high-altitude reds and apple-country autumns — and the hinterlands of both coasts keep a full calendar of food festivals between them.

Groceries and the practical stuff

The two big chains and the discounter anchor everywhere down the coast; independent grocers thin out north of the corner but the markets compensate. Whatever your community eats, Brisbane's south side and the Gold Coast sell it — the multicultural depth is newer than Sydney's or Melbourne's but growing fast, and the master's **Finding your feet & your people** maps where communities cluster.

The rhythm of the week

Nippers is the social engine

Sunday-morning surf lifesaving for kids is how coastal families meet everyone they will ever know here. Joining is the fastest shortcut in the state.

Sport, both codes, all year

League is the religion, union and AFL run deep, netball and touch fill the weeknights. State of Origin nights empty the streets — pick Queensland; it's safer.

The pool is a room of the house

Backyard pools are ordinary infrastructure, pool fencing is strict law, and summer social life happens half-submerged.

Winter is festival season

The dry months carry the calendar — outdoor cinemas, shows, the Ekka in August — because the state schedules its culture for its best weather.

Honest limitations

High culture is thinner than the southern capitals — good and growing in Brisbane, a flight away from the regions.

Summer curbs the outdoor life it advertises: January is for pools, aircon and early mornings, not long lunches outside.

North of the corner, specialist ingredients need planning — every community keeps its list and its Brisbane order.

Reef, rainforest & the coast

Queensland Guide · Chapter 9 of 9



Queensland's weekend argument is unfair: the world's largest reef offshore, the world's oldest rainforest behind it, and a coastline where the ordinary Saturday options would headline other countries' tourism campaigns. You will live where the rest of the world queues to visit.

WHEN TO DO WHAT, UP HERE

Queensland's weekends are governed by a calendar rather than a map, and it runs opposite to the one most arrivals bring with them. Winter is the season for everything.

The wet, and the heat

DEC – MAR

Humid, storm-heavy and the peak of the northern stinger months. The hinterland waterfalls are at their best, and the crowds are at the coast rather than inland.

The turn

APR – MAY

Humidity drops, the water is still warm and the crowds have gone home. Arguably the best few weeks of the year, and the ones locals keep quiet about.

The dry — peak season

JUN – SEP

Dry, blue and mild statewide: the reef at its clearest, the interior at its kindest, and the one stretch of the year when every part of this chapter is at its best at once.

Building again

OCT – NOV

Warming up and quiet, with turtles nesting up the regional coast — the last comfortable window before the wet returns.

Winter being peak season is the single most useful thing to know about living here — it inverts the leave calendar you arrive with. The season notes below fill in the detail.

The water

Whitehaven Beach in the Whitsundays

The reef, as a habit

From Cairns, Townsville or the southern gateways, the Great Barrier Reef is a day boat – snorkelling stops feeling like a bucket-list item and becomes what you do when family visits, and then just what you do.

The beaches, all of them

Forty kilometres of Gold Coast surf, the Sunshine Coast's point breaks, Four Mile at Port Douglas, and the empty regional stretches between – patrolled, learnable and warm most of the year.

The bay islands

Moreton and Straddie are Brisbane's weekend sand – ferries from the suburbs to wild beaches, sand tobogganing and winter whales off the headlands.

The Whitsundays

Seventy-four islands and the country's most famous sail-yourself waters, off Airlie Beach – the long weekend that converts visitors into residents.

Stinger season, honestly

North of about Gladstone, November to May means netted swimming enclosures and stinger suits offshore. Managed, signposted, and part of the northern contract.

Whales in winter

The humpback highway runs the whole coast May to November – Hervey Bay is the world capital of watching them rest.

The green

The Daintree & the wet tropics

The world's oldest rainforest, World Heritage from Townsville to Cooktown – cassowaries, swimming holes and canopy walks, all within FNQ's weekend range.

The hinterlands

Both coasts keep green ranges twenty minutes behind the sand – Springbrook and Tamborine behind the Gold Coast, the Blackall Range behind the Sunshine – waterfalls, lookouts and Sunday-drive villages.

The Scenic Rim

Brisbane's crater-rim backdrop — national parks, farm gates and lodge weekends an hour from the city.

Fraser / K'gari

The world's largest sand island — four-wheel-drive beaches, perched lakes and dingo country, off Hervey Bay.

The outback

Longreach's stockman history, dinosaur country at Winton, and night skies worth the drive — the state's other half, one proper road trip a year.

Useful links

Tourism



The state's official visitor site – regions, the reef and what's on.

(<https://www.queensland.com/>)

Outdoors



Tracks, camping permits and alerts – K'gari and the islands book out early.

(<https://parks.desi.qld.gov.au/>)

The city



Events, festivals and the river city's calendar.

(<https://www.visitbrisbane.com.au/>)

Practical



SEQ journey planning, the Go Card and the flat-fare scheme.

(<https://translink.com.au/>)

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Queensland. Everything national – Medicare, visas, registration, tax, super, schools – lives once in **Moving to Australia**. When you'd like to talk it through, **we're here** – no pressure, no pipeline.